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Private is Not a Dirty Word

We need to recognise diversity and corporate funding of higher education

Are private universities good or bad? There can be no simple answer to this question. It's like saying some Central and state universities are good and some are bad. The same rule applies to private initiatives too. Education follows the simple rule of economics—an increase in demand needs an increase in supply. According to the National Knowledge Commission (NKC), India needs 1,500 universities to fill the gap to reach a conservative gross enrolment ratio of 15 per cent by 2015, which has been overshot by other developing countries like China. The next question that arises is whether government funding is going to be enough? If the Centre

Indian School of Business, NIIT and XRLI have shown that they can also be passionate about education. We should place our trust in other such groups. Foreign institutions such as Stanford and Columbia remain tremendous models of education. We can learn from them and look at the modalities suited to our own country and needs.

THE PROBLEMS...

- ▶ The entry of private players is possible only through legislation, by an act of Parliament, by the state or through the deemed university route. With the multiplicity of regulatory agencies like All India Council of Technical Education, the Bar Council of India and the University Grants Commission, the mandates are not clear.
- ▶ There is no transparency on the entry procedures for private institutions.
- ▶ A large number of institutions are waiting to join the force, but do not have land.

THE SOLUTIONS...

- ▶ Both the NKC and Yashpal Committee have proposed the eradication of the multiplicity of regulators. The NKC recommends the implementation of an independent authority, the Regulatory Authority for Higher Education, which needs only a set of people to supervise the entry requirements, accreditation, licensing and rationalising the entry procedure. The Yashpal Committee has suggested an apex regulatory body, the National Commission for Higher Education and Research, which will bring within it the existing agencies and make entry easier for newer bodies.
- ▶ There is a need to set up clear and transparent accreditation and assessment procedures that are fair to all universities. Four to five agencies should focus on assessing the institutions and bring out a public rating. Each body should be allowed to go to one of these agencies to get a rating that could be available on their websites.
- ▶ Public private partnerships can allow many more private players to start an institution if the government provides land. This will cover a diverse population and different needs of students.
- ▶ We must recognise that diversity and differentiation exist and it may not be possible to implement uniform policies for all.

As told to Purvi Malhotra

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new Central universities are to be set up through the public private partnership mode.

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PRIVATE INSTITUTIONS WILL CATER TO GLOBAL DEMANDS

isn't able to provide the excess supply, then there is no harm in looking at private players. Centre and state-run universities need to offer diverse subjects increasing the choices for students, so that they aren't forced to go abroad and the country can save foreign exchange.

Globalisation has led to greater demand from the industry for different types of jobs, which are being looked at by private players. But it is not justifiable that these institutes churn out unemployable graduates. The call of the hour is not to train students to do a job but to educate them in a particular field. Private players like Birla Institute of Technology and Science, Symbiosis,